'I am commissioned to seize your person, sir,' said Comminges, in the same tone and with the same politeness; 'and if you will believe me you had better spare yourself the trouble of reading that long letter and follow me.'

A thunderbolt falling in the midst of these good people, so peacefully assembled there, would not have produced a more appalling effect. It was a horrible thing at that period to be imprisoned by the enmity of the king. Louvières sprang forward to snatch his sword, which stood against a chair in a corner of the room; but a glance from the worthy Broussel, who in the midst of it all did not lose his presence of mind, checked this foolhardy action of despair. Madame Broussel, separated by the width of the table from her husband, burst into tears, and the young girls clung to their father's arms.

'Come, sir,' said Comminges, 'make haste; you must obey the king.'

'Sir,' said Broussel, 'I am in bad health and cannot give myself up a prisoner in this state; I must have time.'

'It is impossible,' said Comminges; 'the order is strict and must be put into execution this instant.'

'Impossible!' said Louvières; 'sir, beware of driving us to despair.'

'Impossible!' cried a shrill voice from the end of the room.

Comminges turned and saw Dame Nanette, her eyes flashing with anger and a broom in her hand.

'My good Nanette, be quiet, I beseech you,' said Broussel.

'Me! keep quiet while my master is being arrested! he, the support, the liberator, the father of the people! Ah! well, yes; you have to know me yet. Are you going?' added she to Comminges.

The latter smiled.

'Come, sir,' said he, addressing Broussel, 'silence that woman and follow me.'

'Silence me! me! me!' said Nanette. 'Ah! yet one wants some one besides you for that, my fine king's cockatoo! You shall see.' And Dame Nanette sprang to the window, threw it open, and in such a piercing voice that it might have been heard in the square of Notre Dame:

'Help!' she screamed, 'my master is being arrested; the Councillor Broussel is being arrested! Help!'

'Sir,' said Comminges, 'declare yourself at once; will you obey or do you intend to rebel against the king?'

'I obey, I obey, sir!' cried Broussel, trying to disengage himself from the grasp of his two daughters and by a look restrain his son, who seemed determined to dispute authority.

'In that case,' commanded Comminges, 'silence that old woman.'

'Ah! old woman!' screamed Nanette.

And she began to shriek more loudly, clinging to the bars of the window:

'Help! help! for Master Broussel, who is arrested because he has defended the people! Help!'

Comminges seized the servant around the waist and would have dragged her from her post; but at that instant a treble voice, proceeding from a kind of *entresol*, was heard screeching:

'Murder! fire! assassins! Master Broussel is being killed! Master Broussel is being strangled.'

It was Friquet's voice; and Dame Nanette, feeling herself supported, recommenced with all her strength to sound her shrilly squawk.

Many curious faces had already appeared at the windows and the people attracted to the end of the street began to run, first men, then groups, and then a crowd of people; hearing cries and seeing a chariot they could not understand it; but Friquet sprang from the *entresol* on to the top of the carriage.

'They want to arrest Master Broussel!' he cried; 'the guards are in the carriage and the officer is upstairs!'

The crowd began to murmur and approached the house. The two guards who had remained in the lane mounted to the aid of Comminges; those who were in the chariot opened the doors and presented arms.

'Don't you see them?' cried Friquet, 'don't you see? there they are!'

The coachman turning around, gave Friquet a slash with his whip which made him scream with pain.

'Ah! devil's coachman!' cried Friquet, 'you're meddling too! Wait!'

And regaining his *entresol* he overwhelmed the coachman with every projectile he could lay hands on.

The tumult now began to increase; the street was not able to contain the spectators who assembled from every direction; the crowd invaded the space which the dreaded pikes of the guards had till then kept clear between them and the carriage. The soldiers, pushed back by these living walls, were in danger of being crushed against the spokes of the wheels and the panels of

the carriages. The cries which the police officer repeated twenty times: 'In the king's name,' were powerless against this formidable multitude—seemed, on the contrary, to exasperate it still more; when, at the shout, 'In the name of the king,' an officer ran up, and seeing the uniforms ill-treated, he sprang into the scuffle sword in hand, and brought unexpected help to the guards. This gentleman was a young man, scarcely sixteen years of age, now white with anger. He leaped from his charger, placed his back against the shaft of the carriage, making a rampart of his horse, drew his pistols from their holsters and fastened them to his belt, and began to fight with the back sword, like a man accustomed to the handling of his weapon.

During ten minutes he alone kept the crowd at bay; at last Comminges appeared, pushing Broussel before him.

'Let us break the carriage!' cried the people.

'In the king's name!' cried Comminges.

'The first who advances is a dead man!' cried Raoul, for it was in fact he, who, feeling himself pressed and almost crushed by a gigantic citizen, pricked him with the point of his sword and sent him howling back.

Comminges, so to speak, threw Broussel into the carriage and sprang in after him. At this moment a shot was fired and a ball passed through the hat of Comminges and broke the arm of one of the guards. Comminges looked up and saw amidst the smoke the threatening face of Louvières appearing at the window of the second floor.

'Very well, sir,' said Comminges, 'you shall hear of this anon.'

'And you of me, sir,' said Louvières; 'and we shall see then who can speak the loudest.'

Friquet and Nanette continued to shout; the cries, the noise of the shot and the intoxicating smell of powder produced their usual maddening effects.

'Down with the officer! down with him!' was the cry.

'One step nearer,' said Comminges, putting down the sashes, that the interior of the carriage might be well seen, and placing his sword on his prisoner's breast, 'one step nearer, and I kill the prisoner; my orders were to carry him off alive or dead. I will take him dead, that's all.'

A terrible cry was heard, and the wife and daughters of Broussel held up their hands in supplication to the people; the latter knew that this officer,

'Go, Comminges, and may God aid you!'

Comminges immediately left the church and entered the Rue Saint Christophe. Friquet, seeing this fine officer thus walk away, followed by two guards, amused himself by pursuing them and did this so much the more gladly as the ceremony ended at that instant and the king remounted his carriage.

Hardly had the police officer observed Comminges at the end of the Rue Cocatrix when he said one word to the coachman, who at once put his vehicle into motion and drove up before Broussel's door. Comminges knocked at the door at the same moment, and Friquet was waiting behind Comminges until the door should be opened.

'What dost thou there, rascal?' asked Comminges.

'I want to go into Master Broussel's house, captain,' replied Friquet, in that wheedling way the 'gamins' of Paris know so well how to assume when necessary.

'And on what floor does he live?' asked Comminges.

'In the whole house,' said Friquet; 'the house belongs to him; he occupies the second floor when he works and descends to the first to take his meals; he must be at dinner now; it is noon.'

'Good,' said Comminges.

At this moment the door was opened, and having questioned the servant the officer learned that Master Broussel was at home and at dinner.

Broussel was seated at the table with his family, having his wife opposite to him, his two daughters by his side, and his son, Louvières, whom we have already seen when the accident happened to the councillor—an accident from which he had quite recovered—at the bottom of the table. The worthy man, restored to perfect health, was tasting the fine fruit which Madame de Longueville had sent to him.

At sight of the officer Broussel was somewhat moved, but seeing him bow politely he rose and bowed also. Still, in spite of this reciprocal politeness, the countenances of the women betrayed a certain amount of uneasiness; Louvières became very pale and waited impatiently for the officer to explain himself.

'Sir,' said Comminges, 'I am the bearer of an order from the king.'

'Very well, sir,' replied Broussel, 'what is this order?' And he held out his hand.

This noise redoubled when D'Artagnan, with a company of musketeers, placed himself at the gates of Notre Dame to secure the service of the church. He had instructed Porthos to profit by this opportunity to see the ceremony; and Porthos, in full dress, mounted his finest horse, taking the part of supernumerary musketeer, as D'Artagnan had so often done formerly. The sergeant of this company, a veteran of the Spanish wars, had recognised Porthos, his old companion, and very soon all those who served under him were placed in possession of startling facts concerning the honour of the ancient musketeers of Tréville. Porthos had not only been well received by the company, but he was moreover looked on with great admiration.

At ten o'clock the guns of the Louvre announced the departure of the king, and then a movement, similar to that of trees in a stormy wind that bend and writhe with agitated tops, ran though the multitude, which was compressed behind the immovable muskets of the guard. At last the king appeared with the queen in a gilded chariot. Ten other carriages followed, containing the ladies of honour, the officers of the royal household, and the court.

'God save the king!' was the cry in every direction; the young monarch gravely put his head out of the window, looked sufficiently grateful and even bowed; at which the cries of the multitude were renewed.

Just as the court was settling down in the cathedral, a carriage, bearing the arms of Comminges, quitted the line of the court carriages and proceeded slowly to the end of the Rue Saint Christophe, now entirely deserted. When it arrived there, four guards and a police officer, who accompanied it, mounted into the heavy machine and closed the shutters; then through an opening cautiously made, the policeman began to watch the length of the Rue Cocatrix, as if he was waiting for some one.

All the world was occupied with the ceremony, so that neither the chariot nor the precautions taken by those who were within it had been observed. Friquet, whose eye, ever on the alert, could alone have discovered them, had gone to devour his apricots upon the entablature of a house in the square of Notre Dame. Thence he saw the king, the queen and Monsieur Mazarin, and heard the mass as well as if he had been on duty.

Toward the end of the service, the queen, seeing Comminges standing near her, waiting for a confirmation of the order she had given him before quitting the Louvre, said in a whisper:

who was so pale, but who appeared so determined, would keep his word; they continued to threaten, but they began to disperse.

'Drive to the palace,' said Comminges to the coachman, who was by then more dead than alive.

The man whipped his animals, which cleared a way through the crowd; but on arriving on the Quai they were obliged to stop; the carriage was upset, the horses carried off, stifled, mangled by the crowd. Raoul, on foot, for he had not time to mount his horse again, tired, like the guards, of distributing blows with the flat of his sword, had recourse to its point. But this last and dreaded resource served only to exasperate the multitude. From time to time a shot from a musket or the blade of a rapier flashed among the crowd; projectiles continued to hail down from the windows and some shots were heard, the echo of which, though they were probably fired in the air, made all hearts vibrate. Voices, unheard except on days of revolution, were distinguished; faces were seen that only appeared on days of bloodshed. Cries of 'Death! death to the guards! to the Seine with the officer!' were heard above all the noise, deafening as it was. Raoul, his hat in ribbons, his face bleeding, felt not only his strength but also his reason going; a red mist covered his sight, and through this mist he saw a hundred threatening arms stretched over him, ready to seize upon him when he fell. The guards were unable to help any one—each one was occupied with his self-preservation. All was over; carriages, horses, guards, and perhaps even the prisoner were about to be torn to shreds, when all at once a voice well known to Raoul was heard, and suddenly a great sword glittered in the air; at the same time the crowd opened, upset, trodden down, and an officer of the musketeers, striking and cutting right and left, rushed up to Raoul and took him in his arms just as he was about to fall.

'God's blood!' cried the officer, 'have they killed him? Woe to them if it be so!'

And he turned around, so stern with anger, strength and threat, that the most excited rebels hustled back on one another, in order to escape, and some of them even rolled into the Seine.

'Monsieur d'Artagnan!' murmured Raoul.

'Yes, 'sdeath! in person, and fortunately it seems for you, my young friend. Come on, here, you others,' he continued, rising in his stirrups, raising his sword, and addressing those musketeers who had not been able to follow

his rapid onslaught. 'Come, sweep away all that for me! Shoulder muskets! Present arms! Aim— '

At this command the mountain of populace thinned so suddenly that D'Artagnan could not repress a burst of Homeric laughter.

'Thank you, D'Artagnan,' said Comminges, showing half of his body through the window of the broken vehicle, 'thanks, my young friend; your name—that I may mention it to the queen.'

Raoul was about to reply when D'Artagnan bent down to his ear.

'Hold your tongue,' said he, 'and let me answer. Do not lose time, Comminges,' he continued; 'get out of the carriage if you can and make another draw up; be quick, or in five minutes the mob will be on us again with swords and muskets and you will be killed. Hold! there's a carriage coming over yonder.'

Then bending again to Raoul, he whispered: 'Above all things do not divulge your name.'

'That's right. I will go,' said Comminges; 'and if they come back, fire!'

'Not at all—not at all,' replied D'Artagnan; 'let no one move. On the contrary, one shot at this moment would be paid for dearly to-morrow.'

Comminges took his four guards and as many musketeers and ran to the carriage, from which he made the people inside dismount, and brought them to the vehicle which had upset. But when it was necessary to convey the prisoner from one carriage to the other, the people, catching sight of him whom they called their liberator, uttered every imaginable cry and knotted themselves once more around the vehicle.

'Start, start!' said D'Artagnan. 'There are ten men to accompany you. I will keep twenty to hold in check the mob; go, and lose not a moment. Ten men for Monsieur de Comminges.'

As the carriage started off the cries were redoubled and more than ten thousand people thronged the Quai and overflowed the Pont Neuf and adjacent streets. A few shots were fired and one musketeer was wounded.

'Forward!' cried D'Artagnan, driven to extremities, biting his moustache; and then he charged with his twenty men and dispersed them in fear. One man alone remained in his place, gun in hand.

'Ah!' he exclaimed, 'it is thou who wouldst have him assassinated? Wait an instant.' And he pointed his gun at D'Artagnan, who was riding toward

'What doest thou here, good-for-nothing?' she said, 'and why art thou not at Notre Dame?'

'I have been there, mother,' said Friquet, 'but I saw things happen of which Master Broussel ought to be warned, and so with Monsieur Bazin's permission—you know, mother, Monsieur Bazin, the verger—I came to speak to Monsieur Broussel.'

'And what hast thou to say, boy, to Monsieur Broussel?'

'I wish to tell him,' replied Friquet, screaming with all his might, 'that there is a whole regiment of guards coming this way. And as I hear everywhere that at the court they are ill-disposed to him, I wish to warn him, that he may be on his guard.'

Broussel heard the scream of the young oddity, and, enchanted with this excess of zeal, came down to the first floor, for he was, in truth, working in his room on the second.

'Well,' said he, 'friend, what matters the regiment of guards to us, and art thou not mad to make such a disturbance? Knowest thou not that it is the custom of these soldiers to act thus and that it is usual for the regiment to form themselves into two solid walls when the king goes by?'

Friquet counterfeited surprise, and twisting his new cap around in his fingers, said:

'It is not astonishing for you to know it, Monsieur Broussel, who knows everything; but as for me, by holy truth, I did not know it and I thought I would give you good advice; you must not be angry with me for that, Monsieur Broussel.'

'On the contrary, my boy, on the contrary, I am pleased with your zeal. Dame Nanette, look for those apricots which Madame de Longueville sent to us yesterday from Noisy and give half a dozen of them to your son, with a crust of new bread.'

'Oh, thank you, sir, thank you, Monsieur Broussel,' said Friquet; 'I am so fond of apricots!'

Broussel then proceeded to his wife's room and asked for breakfast; it was nine o'clock. The councillor placed himself at the window; the street was completely deserted, but in the distance was heard, like the noise of the tide rushing in, the deep hum of the populous waves increasing now around Notre Dame.

and it produced a great effect. The shops were deserted, houses closed; every one wished to see the young king with his mother, and the famous Cardinal Mazarin whom they hated so much that no one wished to be deprived of his presence. Moreover, great liberty prevailed throughout the immense crowd; every opinion was openly expressed and chorused, so to speak, of coming insurrection, as the thousand bells of all the Paris churches rang out the *Te Deum*. The police belonging to the city being formed by the city itself, nothing threatening presented itself to disturb this concert of universal hatred or freeze the frequent scoffs of slanderous lips.

Nevertheless, at eight o'clock in the morning the regiment of the queen's guards, commanded by Guitant, under whom was his nephew Comminges, marched publicly, preceded by drums and trumpets, filing off from the Palais Royal as far as Notre Dame, a manœuvre which the Parisians witnessed tranquilly, delighted as they were with military music and brilliant uniforms.

Friquet had put on his Sunday clothes, under the pretext of having a swollen face which he had managed to simulate by introducing a handful of cherry kernels into one side of his mouth, and had procured a whole holiday from Bazin. On leaving Bazin, Friquet started off to the Palais Royal, where he arrived at the moment of the turning out of the regiment of guards; and as he had only gone there for the enjoyment of seeing it and hearing the music, he took his place at their head, beating the drum on two pieces of slate and passing from that exercise to that of the trumpet, which he counterfeited quite naturally with his mouth in a manner which had more than once called forth the praises of amateurs of imitative harmony.

This amusement lasted from the Barrière des Sergens to the place of Notre Dame, and Friquet found in it very real enjoyment; but when at last the regiment separated, penetrated the heart of the city and placed itself at the extremity of the Rue Saint Christophe, near the Rue Cocatrix, in which Broussel lived, then Friquet remembered that he had not had breakfast; and after thinking in which direction he had better turn his steps in order to accomplish this important act of the day, he reflected deeply and decided that Councillor Broussel should bear the cost of this repast.

In consequence he took to his heels, arrived breathlessly at the councillor's door, and knocked violently.

His mother, the councillor's old servant, opened it.

him at full speed. D'Artagnan bent down to his horse's neck, the young man fired, and the ball severed the feathers from the hat. The horse started, brushed against the imprudent man, who thought by his strength alone to stay the tempest, and he fell against the wall. D'Artagnan pulled up his horse, and whilst his musketeers continued to charge, he returned and bent with drawn sword over the man he had knocked down.

'Oh, sir!' exclaimed Raoul, recognizing the young man as having seen him in the Rue Cocatrix, 'spare him! it is his son!'

D'Artagnan's arm dropped to his side. 'Ah, you are his son!' he said; 'that is a different thing.'

'Sir, I surrender,' said Louvières, presenting his unloaded musket to the officer.

'Eh, no! do not surrender, egad! On the contrary, be off, and quickly. If I take you, you will be hung!'

The young man did not wait to be told twice, but passing under the horse's head disappeared at the corner of the Rue Guénégaud.

'I'faith!' said D'Artagnan to Raoul, 'you were just in time to stay my hand. He was a dead man; and on my honour, if I had discovered that it was his son, I should have regretted having killed him.'

'Ah! sir!' said Raoul, 'allow me, after thanking you for that poor fellow's life, to thank you on my own account. I too, sir, was almost dead when you arrived.'

'Wait, wait, young man; do not fatigue yourself with speaking. We can talk of it afterward.'

Then seeing that the musketeers had cleared the Quai from the Pont Neuf to the Quai Saint Michael, he raised his sword for them to double their speed. The musketeers trotted up, and at the same time the ten men whom D'Artagnan had given to Comminges appeared.

'Halloo!' cried D'Artagnan; 'has something fresh happened?'

'Eh, sir!' replied the sergeant, 'their vehicle has broken down a second time; it really must be doomed.'

'They are bad managers,' said D'Artagnan, shrugging his shoulders. 'When a carriage is chosen, it ought to be strong. The carriage in which a Broussel is to be arrested ought to be able to bear ten thousand men.'

'What are your commands, lieutenant?'

'Take the detachment and conduct him to his place.'

'But you will be left alone?'

'Certainly. So you suppose I have need of an escort? Go.'

The musketeers set off and D'Artagnan was left alone with Raoul.

'Now,' he said, 'are you in pain?'

'Yes; my head is not only swimming but burning.'

'What's the matter with this head?' said D'Artagnan, raising the battered hat. 'Ah! ah! a bruise.'

'Yes, I think I received a flower-pot upon my head.'

'Brutes!' said D'Artagnan. 'But were you not on horseback? you have spurs.'

'Yes, but I got down to defend Monsieur de Comminges and my horse was taken away. Here it is, I see.'

At this very moment Friquet passed, mounted on Raoul's horse, waving his parti-coloured cap and crying, 'Broussel! Broussel!'

'Halloo! stop, rascal!' cried D'Artagnan. 'Bring hither that horse.'

Friquet heard perfectly, but he pretended not to do so and tried to continue his road. D'Artagnan felt inclined for an instant to pursue Master Friquet, but not wishing to leave Raoul alone he contented himself with taking a pistol from the holster and cocking it.

Friquet had a quick eye and a fine ear. He saw D'Artagnan's movement, heard the sound of the click, and stopped at once.

'Ah! it is you, your honour,' he said, advancing toward D'Artagnan; 'and I am truly pleased to meet you.'

D'Artagnan looked attentively at Friquet and recognised the little chorister of the Rue de la Calandre.

'Ah! 'tis thou, rascal!' said he, 'come here: so thou hast changed thy trade; thou art no longer a choir boy nor a tavern boy; thou hast become a horse stealer?'

'Ah, your honour, how can you say so?' exclaimed Friquet. 'I was seeking the gentleman to whom this horse belongs—an officer, brave and handsome as a youthful Cæsar;' then, pretending to see Raoul for the first time:

'Ah! but if I mistake not,' continued he, 'here he is; you won't forget the boy, sir.'

Raoul put his hand in his pocket.

Chapter XLIV

Te Deum for the Victory of Lens

THE bustle which had been observed by Henrietta Maria and for which she had vainly sought to discover a reason, was occasioned by the battle of Lens, announced by the prince's messenger, the Duc de Châtillon, who had taken such a noble part in the engagement; he was, besides, charged to hang five and twenty flags, taken from the Lorraine party, as well as from the Spaniards, upon the arches of Notre Dame.

Such news was decisive; it destroyed, in favour of the court, the struggle commenced with parliament. The motive given for all the taxes summarily imposed and to which the parliament had made opposition, was the necessity of sustaining the honour of France and the uncertain hope of beating the enemy. Now, since the affair of Nordlingen, they had experienced nothing but reverses; the parliament had a plea for calling Mazarin to account for imaginary victories, always promised, ever deferred; but this time there really had been fighting, a triumph and a complete one. And this all knew so well that it was a double victory for the court, a victory at home and abroad; so that even when the young king learned the news he exclaimed, 'Ah, gentlemen of the parliament, we shall see what you will say now!' Upon which the queen had pressed the royal child to her heart, whose haughty and unruly sentiments were in such harmony with her own. A council was called on the same evening, but nothing transpired of what had been decided on. It was only known that on the following Sunday a *Te Deum* would be sung at Notre Dame in honour of the victory of Lens.

The following Sunday, then, the Parisians arose with joy; at that period a *Te Deum* was a grand affair; this kind of ceremony had not then been abused

'When shall we land in England?' he asked; but De Winter seemed not to hear his words and made no reply.

'Hold, Athos,' said Aramis, 'perhaps there is yet time. See if he is still in the same place.'

Athos turned around with an effort; the sight of the young man was evidently painful to him, and there he still was, in fact, on the rock, the beacon shedding around him, as it were, a doubtful aureole.

'Decidedly, Aramis,' said Athos, 'I think I was wrong not to let you fire.'

'Hold your tongue,' replied Aramis; 'you would make me weep, if such a thing were possible.'

At this moment they were hailed by a voice from the sloop and a few seconds later men, servants and baggage were aboard. The captain was only waiting for his passengers; hardly had they put foot on deck ere her head was turned towards Hastings, where they were to disembark. At this instant the three friends turned, in spite of themselves, a last look on the rock, upon the menacing figure which pursued them and now stood out with a distinctness still. Then a voice reached them once more, sending this threat: 'To our next meeting, sirs, in England.'

'What are you about?' asked D'Artagnan.

'To give ten francs to this honest fellow,' replied Raoul, taking a pistole from his pocket.

'Ten kicks on his back!' said D'Artagnan; 'be off, you little villain, and forget not that I have your address.'

Friquet, who did not expect to be let off so cheaply, bounded off like a gazelle up the Quai a la Rue Dauphine, and disappeared. Raoul mounted his horse, and both leisurely took their way to the Rue Tiquetonne.

D'Artagnan watched over the youth as if he had been his own son.

They arrived without accident at the Hotel de la Chevrette.

The handsome Madeleine announced to D'Artagnan that Planchet had returned, bringing Mousqueton with him, who had heroically borne the extraction of the ball and was as well as his state would permit.

D'Artagnan desired Planchet to be summoned, but he had disappeared.

'Then bring some wine,' said D'Artagnan. 'You are much pleased with yourself,' said he to Raoul when they were alone, 'are you not?'

'Well, yes,' replied Raoul. 'It seems to me I did my duty. I defended the king.'

'And who told you to defend the king?'

'The Comte de la Fère himself.'

'Yes, the king; but to-day you have not fought for the king, you have fought for Mazarin; which is not quite the same thing.'

'But you yourself?'

'Oh, for me; that is another matter. I obey my captain's orders. As for you, your captain is the prince, understand that rightly; you have no other. But has one ever seen such a wild fellow,' continued he, 'making himself a Mazarinist and helping to arrest Broussel! Breathe not a word of that, or the Comte de la Fère will be furious.'

'You think the count will be angry with me?'

'Think it? I'm certain of it; were it not for that, I should thank you, for you have worked for us. However, I scold you instead of him, and in his place; the storm will blow over more easily, believe me. And moreover, my dear child,' continued D'Artagnan, 'I am making use of the privilege conceded to me by your guardian.'

'I do not understand you, sir,' said Raoul.

D'Artagnan rose, and taking a letter from his writing-desk, presented it to Raoul. The face of the latter became serious when he had cast his eyes upon the paper.

'Oh, *mon Dieu!*' he said, raising his fine eyes to D'Artagnan, moist with tears, 'the count has left Paris without seeing me?'

'He left four days ago,' said D'Artagnan.

'But this letter seems to intimate that he is about to incur danger, perhaps death.'

'He—he—incur danger of death! No, be not anxious; he is travelling on business and will return ere long. I hope you have no repugnance to accept me as your guardian in the interim.'

'Oh, no, Monsieur d'Artagnan,' said Raoul, 'you are such a brave gentleman and the Comte de la Fère has so much affection for you!'

'Eh! Egad! love me too; I will not torment you much, but only on condition that you become a Frondist, my young friend, and a hearty Frondist, too.'

'But can I continue to visit Madame de Chevreuse?'

'I should say you could! and the coadjutor and Madame de Longueville; and if the worthy Broussel were there, whom you so stupidly helped arrest, I should tell you to excuse yourself to him at once and kiss him on both cheeks.'

'Well, sir, I will obey you, although I do not understand you.'

'It is unnecessary for you to understand. Hold,' continued D'Artagnan, turning toward the door, which had just opened, 'here is Monsieur du Vallon, who comes with his coat torn.'

'Yes, but in exchange,' said Porthos, covered with perspiration and soiled by dust, 'in exchange, I have torn many skins. Those wretches wanted to take away my sword! Deuce take 'em, what a popular commotion!' continued the giant, in his quiet manner; 'but I knocked down more than twenty with the hilt of Balizarde. A draught of wine, D'Artagnan.'

'Oh, I'll answer for you,' said the Gascon, filling Porthos's glass to the brim; 'but when you have drunk, give me your opinion.'

'Upon what?' asked Porthos.

'Look here,' resumed D'Artagnan; 'here is Monsieur de Bragelonne, who determined at all risks to aid the arrest of Broussel and whom I had great difficulty to prevent defending Monsieur de Comminges.'

The young man heard these words and bent so forward over the rock that one might have supposed he was about to precipitate himself from it.

'Yes, it is I, my uncle—I, the son of Milady—I, the monk—I, the secretary and friend of Cromwell—*I know you now*, both you and your companions.'

In that boat sat three men, unquestionably brave, whose courage no man would have dared dispute; nevertheless, at that voice, that accent and those gestures, they felt a chill access of terror cramp their veins. As for Grimaud, his hair stood on end and drops of sweat ran down his brow.

'Ah!' exclaimed Aramis, 'that is the nephew, the monk, and the son of Milady, as he says himself.'

'Alas, yes,' murmured De Winter.

'Then wait,' said Aramis; and with the terrible coolness which on important occasions he showed, he took one of the muskets from Tony, shouldered and aimed it at the young man, who stood, like the accusing angel, upon the rock.

'Fire!' cried Grimaud, unconsciously.

Athos threw himself on the muzzle of the gun and arrested the shot which was about to be fired.

'The devil take you,' said Aramis. 'I had him so well at the point of my gun I should have sent a ball into his breast.'

'It is enough to have killed the mother,' said Athos, hoarsely.

'The mother was a wretch, who struck at us all and at those dear to us.'

'Yes, but the son has done us no harm.'

Grimaud, who had risen to watch the effect of the shot, fell back hopeless, wringing his hands.

The young man burst into a laugh.

'Ah, it is certainly you!' he cried. 'I know you even better now.'

His mocking laugh and threatening words passed over their heads, carried by the breeze, until lost in the depths of the horizon. Aramis shuddered.

'Be calm,' exclaimed Athos, 'for Heaven's sake! have we ceased to be men?'

'No,' said Aramis, 'but that fellow is a fiend; and ask the uncle whether I was wrong to rid him of his dear nephew.'

De Winter only replied by a groan.

'It was all up with him,' continued Aramis; 'ah I much fear that with all your wisdom such mercy yet will prove supernal folly.'

Athos took Lord de Winter's hand and tried to turn the conversation.

'Nothing,' replied De Winter; 'nothing; and yet in passing the heights it seemed to me— ' and he again turned round.

Athos glanced at Aramis.

'But let us go,' continued De Winter; 'let us be off; the boat must be waiting for us and there is our sloop at anchor—do you see it there? I wish I were on board already,' and he looked back again.

'He has seen him,' said Athos, in a low tone, to Aramis.

They had reached the ladder which led to the boat. De Winter made the grooms who carried the arms and the porters with the luggage descend first and was about to follow them.

At this moment Athos perceived a man walking on the seashore parallel to the jetty, and hastening his steps, as if to reach the other side of the port, scarcely twenty steps from the place of embarking. He fancied in the darkness that he recognised the young man who had questioned him. Athos now descended the ladder in his turn, without losing sight of the young man. The latter, to make a short cut, had appeared on a sluice.

'He certainly bodes us no good,' said Athos; 'but let us embark; once out at sea, let him come.'

And Athos sprang into the boat, which was immediately pushed off and which soon sped seawards under the efforts of four stalwart rowers.

But the young man had begun to follow, or rather to advance before the boat. She was obliged to pass between the point of the jetty, surmounted by a beacon just lighted, and a rock which jutted out. They saw him in the distance climbing the rock in order to look down upon the boat as it passed.

'Ay, but,' said Aramis, 'that young fellow is decidedly a spy.'

'Which is the young man?' asked De Winter, turning around.

'He who followed us and spoke to us awaits us there; behold!'

De Winter turned and followed the direction of Aramis's finger. The beacon bathed with light the little strait through which they were about to pass and the rock where the young man stood with bare head and crossed arms.

'It is he!' exclaimed De Winter, seizing the arm of Athos; 'it is he! I thought I recognised him and I was not mistaken.'

'Whom do you mean?' asked Aramis.

'Milady's son,' replied Athos.

'The monk!' exclaimed Grimaud.

'The devil!' said Porthos; 'and his guardian, what would he have said to that?'

'Do you hear?' interrupted D'Artagnan; 'become a Frondist, my friend, belong to the Fronde, and remember that I fill the count's place in everything;' and he jingled his money.

'Will you come?' said he to Porthos.

'Where?' asked Porthos, filling a second glass of wine.

'To present our respects to the cardinal.'

Porthos swallowed the second glass with the same grace with which he had imbibed the first, took his beaver and followed D'Artagnan. As for Raoul, he remained bewildered with what he had seen, having been forbidden by D'Artagnan to leave the room until the tumult was over.

The sun had left a single golden cloud